

CENTRAL AFRICA

IN FERTILE CENTRAL AFRICA, steaming rain forests cluster around the Equator, and the mighty Congo River snakes its way through Congo and the Democratic Republic of Congo. In the 1400s, Europeans began a cruel slave trade here; by the late 19th century, the region was colonized. Independence came in the 1960s, but democracy has been slow to arrive.

The area has met with mixed fortunes. Countries range from stable, prosperous Cameroon to the Central African Republic, which has been crushed by poverty and harsh dictatorships.

